



**Steep decline:** England lost the series 4–1 after a five-wicket defeat at the SCG, their Ashes campaign ending inside 11 days following losses in Perth, Brisbane and Adelaide. AFP

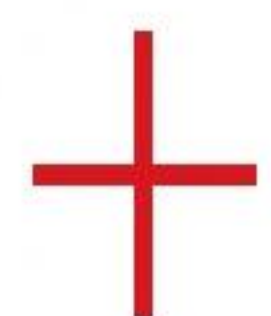
situation. With the management also ignoring some of the unforgivable and irresponsible shots played by the batters, the fear of being left out simply is not there. **Valuing playing for your country and putting a minimum price of a century on your wicket is something only the great Joe Root does.** The others could not be bothered, as they knew they were unlikely to be left out of the squad.

What the media calls fearless cricket today often looks more like couldn't-care-less cricket. With the guarantee of a central contract and the various T20 leagues around the cricketing world, there is no worry about how to put food on the table, which was the case when these facilities were not there and losing a Test place meant going back to mundane first-class cricket, where one hardly earned enough, let alone saved for a

rainy day.

This is not to begrudge the current cricketer at all. Far from it. As Sir Don Bradman said, it should be the endeavour of every cricketer to try and leave the game in a better place than when he found it. So, when the modern cricketer makes good money, it is a great thing, as it encourages and draws more youngsters to the game. That is why it is disappointing when some forget their responsibility to the game and play reckless cricket, letting their team and country down. Winning and losing are part of sport, but the effort has to be wholehearted.

How many in the England team that lost the Ashes series can put their hands on their hearts and say that they gave it everything, not just physically but, more crucially, temperamentally, in the series? You tell me.



**Valuing playing for your country and putting a minimum price of a century on your wicket is something only the great Joe Root does. The others could not be bothered, as they knew they were unlikely to be left out of the squad.**